

You Do Not Have to Keep Extending the Same Version of Yourself"

ROOPA KUDVA
Former MD & CEO, CRISIL

KUDVA'S BIGGEST CAREER reinvention began when she left the corner office at CRISIL for an open office at Omidyar Network India. After eight years as MD and CEO of CRISIL, she moved into impact investing, evaluating young ventures, and working with entrepreneurs, many in their 20s.

"I went from a corner office with a team of five dedicated staff to sitting in an open office with no cabin and a shared assistant," she says. The shift required a different approach to assessing businesses.

"I had to move from thinking primarily about risks to thinking more about possibilities while evaluating organisations," she says.

Over the following decade, Kudva deepened her experience in impact investing and served on boards including Infosys, Nestlé India, Tata AIA Life Insurance, and IIM Ahmedabad. Her work at Omidyar focused on India's "Next Half Billion"—lower-income and lower-middle-income populations.

Now in her 60s, she has stepped back from professional commitments to make room for writing, reading, travel, exercise, family and friends, while continuing to speak on business and technology, and pursue philanthropy.

"When you're running an organisation, somebody else owns your diary. Now, you know, it's a much more conscious decision that I make. Does this deserve my time?" she says.

Kudva identifies four aspects that professionals typically deal as they transition to a new chapter: identity, daily routine, intellectual stimulation, and purpose. She also cautions against treating a board position, investment role or mentoring assignment as a scaled-down version of an executive job.

"A board position is not a smaller CEO job. Investing is not operating."

"There is actually a double disadvantage which older women face. An experienced man leaving a senior executive role is often seen as someone whose decades of experience can be used, can be put to use as a board member, as an advisor or mentor. I'm not sure that women are always viewed through quite the same lens," she says. Kudva links the disadvantage older women face to the pipeline into senior leadership. Fewer than 5% of NIFTY 500 companies are led by women, she points out.

"You do not have to keep extending the same version of yourself." She believes that at different stages of life, one can really choose to begin again.